cuisine, and I loved it.

On December 10, a few days after Babbie Whipple had given birth to a baby girl, we all went to a Chinese restaurant, where the Chinese consul and his wife did the ordering and ate with us. We had dishes we had never had before and were never to have again. All I could say in my diary was "Two soups, five main courses, all new, all delicious, all indescribable." It was the best Chinese dinner I have ever had.

8

On December 20, I completed the outline of The Stars, like Dust— along with the first two chapters written out in full, exactly as Bradbury had asked me to do. It was all ready to be taken to New York.

On the twenty-third Kupchan drove us to New York for Christmas-New Year's, and the next day we had an old-fashioned feast at the Blugermans'. Mary had prepared nothing less than a twenty-six-pound turkey. The five of us managed to finish nearly half of it at dinner.

On Christmas Day it was my parents' turn, and after visiting them I delivered the chapters and outline to Bradbury.

9

In those days, Gertrude and I were going through a fit of playing charades. We engaged in it at every opportunity and, of course, it was bound to give rise to occasional frustrations that were murderous at the time and funny afterward.

Sometimes the frustrations were deliberately arranged. After all, as one played charades and grew more expert, one developed a set of sig-

nals that turned it into almost a deaf-and-dumb language so that no phrase remained unpenetrated long. To cure dullness, there was occasionally a conspiracy to arrange to have a relative newcomer deliver a phrase we all knew but deliberately misguessed. No matter what he or she signaled, all the rats in the audience assiduously suggested synonyms and never landed on the right spot. It was fun to watch the demonstrator slowly curdle and disintegrate, but we could never go too far, for either one of us would start laughing or we would fear a real stroke. We would confess and there would be a furious demonstrator who would take hours to recede from his or her high fever.